

that BJP seemed to have lost forever. The all-powerful RSS general secretary Mohan Bhagwat camped in the Capital and worked out all the details. On December 8, he drove to Vajpayee's residence along with RSS joint general secretary Suresh Soni. They were joined by Rajnath and the blueprint of the succession drafted. Advani had been keen that Vajpayee make the announcement but the latter's health did not permit this. This was one reason for the delay. Moreover, Vajpayee pointed out that theirs was not a feudal party whereby he should announce his successor. It was suggested that the party chief should make the announcement. Rajnath was hesitant. Perhaps he felt it would be a bit presumptuous on his part. In 1995 when Advani had announced Vajpayee's name as the party's prime ministerial candidate, he was BJP pres-

POWER OF TWO: Vajpayee passes the leadership baton to Advani

ident. But while Advani was Vajpayee's peer, Rajnath is much junior to Advani in party seniority. Vajpayee then suggested that Rajnath find an appropriate mechanism to make the announcement. Finally it was decided that Vajpayee's message endorsing Advani would be taken to the parliamentary board meeting which would take the decision. Two days later the members of the parliamentary board were called for an almost impromptu meeting—Jaswant Singh and Sushma Swaraj who were out of town, had to rush back. Although Swaraj missed the meeting she dropped in at Advani's house later with flowers and support. Advani was formally informed of

RSS knows it needs a strong leader to unite BJP and lead NDA

the decision only when he asked why the meeting had been called.

The decision to project Advani as the party's prime ministerial face could strengthen Rajnath's position too. For a while now, a section of the party had been trying to oust

Rajnath by pushing for Advani's return to the organisation. But Advani has distanced himself from this group, especially after the party's executive meet in Bhopal this September. RSS sources claim that the understanding with Advani is that he would take Rajnath along with him instead of sidelining him. Foiled by Advani, this group had floated Modi's name as an alternate leader. This too has been checked by Advani's succession. Forget the central BJP leadership, even the Sangh is not too keen on propping up a powerful Modi who has made it clear that he does not need anyone's support or advice. The only one who has any influence over Modi is Advani. It made sense to strengthen his hand.

Moreover, the two have always stood by each other. Modi supported his mentor during his post-Jinnah remark days and Advani did not encourage the Keshubhai Patel rebellion. The equation is unlikely to change now. RSS sources say that Advani has been asked not to alienate Joshi, a parivar favourite. Which perhaps explained Joshi's smiling presence on the dais. One trade-off could be that Joshi takes over as the party's leader in the Rajya Sabha, replacing Advani loyalist, Jaswant Singh. Having settled the divisive leadership stakes, BJP now hopes to present a united face for the Lok Sabha polls, which it clearly feels will happen sooner rather than later.

Can the Advani-Rajnath combination bring BJP back to its 1999 high of 182 seats from its current tally of 129? Vajpayee was the mass mobiliser while Advani could inspire the workers more than the voters. His 2004 *Suraksha yatra* did not move the masses the same way as his 1989 *Somnath yatra* did. But the appointment could change all that. NDA allies that had scoffed at



ADVANI FUTURE HOPE

THE NUTS AND BOLTS MAN:

The quintessential organisational leader who takes care of the details. His constituency is the worker rather than the voter.

BJP'S SARDAR PATEL: His hawkish and aggressive image came in the way of his prime ministerial ambitions. Has now toned it down considerably.

TEAM BUILDER: Inspires loyalty and knows how to build a team. Thinks in English. Media savvy. Comfortable in Parliament debates and small talk.

BLUEPRINT FOR THE FUTURE: Nearly two decades ago he took the party's tally from two to 89. Now he has to do it again, bring BJP to power once more.